Bún chả

A beloved Hanoi street food, and perhaps one of my favourite dishes. Juicy grilled pork served with thin rice vermicelli, fresh herbs, and a light sweet-and-sour fish sauce. It's a burst of flavour that keeps both tourists and locals coming back for more.

4 servings 55 minutes

INGREDIENTS

For the grilled meat (chả)

1200g pork meat, half minced and half sliced into 2-inch pieces
For each type of meat: 1 tbsp minced garlic and onion, 2 tsps oyster sauce, 2 tsps fish sauce, 2 tsps MSG (optional), 1 tsp sugar, 1 tsp salt, 1 tsp oil, black pepper

For the salad

½ cucumber and ½ carrot, thinly sliced
2 tsps sugar, juice of ½ lime, pinch of salt
1 clove of garlic, crushed

For the noodles

300 g dried rice vermicelli
1 L of water

For the sauce

24 tbsps (360 ml) water
4 tbsps sugar
6 tbsps fish sauce
4 tbsps lime juice
1 tbsps minced garlic
Sliced chili (optional)

Note: This dish is best enjoyed hot. There are many ways to eat bún chả, but I like to mix a little noodles, meat, and salad in a bowl, then ladle over plenty of sauce to coat everything.

DIRECTIONS

1. Boil the rice vermicelli according to package instructions. Drain and set aside.
2. Marinate the cucumber and carrot with sugar, lime juice, and garlic. Set aside.
3. Marinate the minced pork and sliced pork separately with onion, oyster sauce, fish sauce, black pepper, MSG, and sugar. Add a pinch of minced garlic to the minced pork. Marinate for at least 20 minutes.
4. Form the minced pork into small patties. Grill alongside the sliced pork.
   - Oven: Fan-forced grill at 250°C for 20 minutes
   - Air fryer: 250°C for 15 minutes
5. Make the sauce: Bring water and sugar to a gentle simmer until dissolved. Turn off the heat and stir in fish sauce, lime juice, garlic, and chilli (if using). Serve hot.
6. Serve the grilled meat with rice vermicelli and cucumber salad.

Hi, it's Nguyen. In case you have any questions about the recipe, feel free to reach out to me at nguyenhnguyen09@gmail.com. Enjoy!

Bún sườn

This is a dish that my Mum would make us for breakfast (yes, we often have savoury breakfasts in Vietnam!), or even a weekend dinner. The broth is light yet flavourful, and the meat tender and falling off the bone. Needless to say, this for sure helps us to wake up in the morning!

4 servings | 1 hour 15 mins

INGREDIENTS

For the broth

500 g pork ribs, cut into 2-inch cubes
300g pineapple
2 tomatoes, cut into wedges
½ onion, minced
1 tbsp fish sauce, and extra fish sauce to season to taste
2 tsps MSG (optional), 1 tsp sugar, salt to taste, sliced chili (optional)
2 L water

For the noodles

300 g dried rice vermicelli
1 L of water

For the side vegetables (optional)

¼ lettuce, thinly sliced
Fresh herbs, like coriander and blanched bean sprouts

Note: We Vietnamese love to pair our dishes with fresh herbs and vegetables. The side vegetables in this soup help to balance out the bold flavours and add a depth of texture and freshness to the dish!

DIRECTIONS

1. Prepare the broth: saute the onions with a dash of oil in a large pot until fragrant. Add half of the tomatoes and saute with fish sauce. When the tomato softens, add the pork ribs and saute until the pork ribs firm up slightly. Add water, pineapple, sugar, and leave to simmer for at least 1 hour, or until the meat is fall-off-the-bone tender.
2. Boil the rice vermicelli according to package instructions. Drain and set aside.
3. Prepare the side vegetables: slice lettuce and arrange fresh herbs and bean sprouts.
4. After about 1 hour of cooking, check on the broth. Season with fish sauce and/or salt to taste.
5. Divide the noodles into bowls, and warm them up warm them up (microwave for about 30 seconds, if needed). Ladle on the soup, and enjoy it with the fresh vegetables!

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Bánh trôi

4 servings 45 minutes

This sweet treat has its own day: Tết Hàn Thực (Cold Food Festival), a holiday celebrated on the 3rd day of the 3rd lunar month to honor ancestors and for family gathering. The little glutinous rice balls are associated with the legend of the birth of the Vietnamese people, and the use of glutinous rice flour and palm sugar is a tribute to the country's agricultural traditions.

INGREDIENTS

400 g glutinous rice flour
Palm sugar, cut into small cubes
Water (approx. 1 part water to 2 parts flour)
2 L of water to boil the bánh trôi
Toasted sesame seed

Fun fact: Bánh trôi is such an iconic and traditional dessert that it has its own poem. The poem 'Bánh trôi nước' by Hồ Xuân Hương, often known as 'Queen of Nôm poetry', uses the image of bánh trôi as a metaphor for the hardship and spirit of the women of the time.

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DIRECTIONS

1. Mix the flour with water. Gradually add water while mixing, until it forms a soft dough that is pliable, but not sticky. Leave to rest for at least 30 minutes.
2. Chop the palm sugar into small cubes.

3. Take a pinch of flour, add the sugar cube in the middle, and roll into a small ball. The ball should be 1 inch in diameter.
4. Prepare a large pot to boil the pastries. Bring 2 L of water to boil, reduce to medium-high heat, and add the rice balls. Boil until the rice balls float to the top and become slightly translucent. Use a slotted spoon to gather and drop them into a cold water bath for 2 - 3 minutes.
5. Gather the rice balls and transfer to a dish. Sprinkle on some toasted sesame seeds and enjoy!

TIPS

I personally prefer to have bánh trôi the next day. We would warm them up in the microwave for a minute or so, and the sugar cube would melt into a syrup, that burst open and coat the rice ball when you bite into it.